man, while those characteristics of lions that he lacks are eliminated from the sense of 'lion'. This is particularly important for ***Advaita Vedantins***. They think that in the scriptural statement, 'That thou art', 'thou' stands for the individual self and 'that' for the Absolute Reality. But if the statement asserts the identity of the soul and the absolute, 'thou' must drop its normal meaning of human personality and just mean the self-evident and self-luminous soul.

Further reading: Bartley 2002; Gerow 2001; Ingalls, Masson and Patwhardan 1990

Lakshanam (definition) (generally – distinguishing mark): a definition distinguishes its object from whatever differs in nature from that object. It must cite at least one uniquely identifying characteristic (*asadharana-dharma*). For example, possession of the dewlap is cited in the case of the species cow, that being sufficient to distinguish cows from buffaloes with which they might be confused.

There is a distinction between essential and incidental definitions, the latter specifying a property that while not being essential to the object is one by which it can be known. The Supreme Being may be defined essentially as 'reality, knowledge, infinite', and incidentally as the cause of the cosmos where being the cause of the cosmos is not a necessary property of ***Brahman***.

Because statements of definition have a primarily negative import, differentiating their subject from everything else, some thinkers in the ***Advaita-Vedanta*** tradition interpreted some *Upanishadic* statements as definitions of ***Brahman***.

A definition must avoid the defects of: over-extension (*ativyapti*), for example, 'cows have horns'; under-extension (*avyapti*), where the definition fails to apply